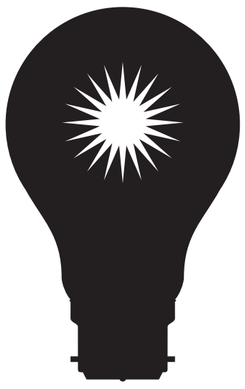
FIELDGUIDE

FIND PLAY MAKE



INSIGHT JOURNALISM

FIELDGUIDE IS AN OCCASIONAL COLLECTIVE AND SOMETIMES JOURNAL FOR PEOPLE INTERESTED IN DESIGN, TECHNOLOGY AND SOCIETY AND THE INTERSECTIONS WHERE THEY OVERLAP.

OUR MOTTO IS: FIND PLAY MAKE.

IT UNDERPINS OUR WORK. WE CELEBRATE PROCESS AND OUTCOME, UNCOVERING INSIGHTS THROUGH INVESTIGATION; PLAYING WITH IDEAS AND TECHNOLOGY TO DISCOVER NEW OPPORTUNITIES; AND MAKING ENGAGING, ENTERTAINING, AMUSING AND AMAZING ARTIFACTS THAT TELL THEIR OWN STORIES AND ENCOURAGE CONVERSATION.

THE INSIGHT JOURNALISM ISSUE IS THE FIRST IN A SERIES OF OCCASIONAL FIELDGUIDE PUBLICATIONS.

START

Insight Journalism is a potentially powerful way to explore and look at the world.

In part it is a story of what happens when a journalist meets a designer but it's also testimony to the evolving way that our research community funders are working in a truly interdisciplinary space.

It was the Research Councils UK that locked the academic and journalist, Paul Egglestone and I in a hotel in High Wycombe with the task of designing for a digital world. This was where the initial idea of Insight Journalism started.

We both feel that we've arrived at the point where we want to tell you our story and for you to tell it back to us in new ways and new forms. Take it as you will. Run with it. Adapt it. Drop it. Or if you want, ignore it!

In this edition of Fieldguide we give you starting points, notes and experiences so you can start to use Insight Journalism to uncover insights.

What do we mean by Insight Journalism? After three years of working with communities and a year going gonzo in New York, Paul and I currently describe it as:

"A process of 'filtering and mediation' that fits between the world as it exists and what we can do in it. Really it's about the story and the process through which the story is read and understood for the purpose of developing an insightful response that enables [re]action"

Essentially all of the thinking in this Fieldguide has come out of two research-funded projects.

The first, BESPOKE was an exploration of citizen journalism as a tool for community innovation.

BESPOKE WAS CITIZEN JOURNALISM AS A TOOL FOR COMMUNITY INNOVATION

The second was an experiment with Gonzo Journalism as a research methodology for gaining insights from a collaboration between MIT and Punchdrunk to create an immersive theatre experience in New York.

These are two highly contrasting and provocative environments to test our embryonic proposition that journalism is an effective tool for drawing out meaningful insights about the world. And what we want to do is get you helping us to test this proposition further. Read on!

Jon

DESIGNER

Why would designers use Insight Journalism and when is it appropriate? To find out, Jon starts to pen out some of the value it gives to a design team.

Designers have always drawn insight and inspiration from the world around them – most of what we do is grounded on this, and formally recognised in user centred design which places peoples' known and unknown needs at the heart of the way we design.

Over the last 15 years we have seen the creation of tools and approaches that can be plugged into stages of design projects to create ideas, build interfaces, iterate projects and evaluate outcomes.

IDEO's methods cards are the iconic representation of theses tools and approaches. The surprising thing for me is that while we have used anything from 'probes' to 'performance' and have employed ethnographers and anthropologists, the design community has overlooked journalists as a way of finding and reporting insights.

When I met Paul we started to chat about the role of journalism and the idea that finding things out is really something journalists do rather well.

Then we moved onto the convergence of people using the web to blog, report and reflect before stumbling across the idea of journalism as an insight tool within the design process.

What we didn't know at the time but we did work out over two years… is the thing we're calling Insight Journalism and the challenge to create a new form of journalism that exposes insights within stories – insights that are demonstrably useful to the design team.

During the BESPOKE project we worked with professional hacks photojournalists and citizen journalists who were given anything from zero to six months on-the-job mentoring and support.

THE STORIES CREATED BY THE COMMUNITY WOULD LEAD ONTO THE CREATION OF IDEAS

This gave us as a design team a unique and incredible range of media to work with. We would review the stories created by the community and generate insights that would lead onto the creation of ideas.

Many of the ideas were deemed good ideas because of the 'strength' of the insights and good ideas are what the world needs right now. Good ideas that lead designers into dealing with all manner of things – from how we design for communities, to how we design for remote audiences, to the way we harness digital technology in our homes.

JOURNALIST

We asked John Mills, a researcher and editor on Media Journalism at the University of Central Lancaster (UCLan) to tell us about what Insight Journalism means to a journalist.

John has a former life as a regional editor of print and online content. He once told me he would regularly produce 200 words of ready-to-go copy in 10 minutes.

FG: What is your take on Insight Journalism and Gonzo Insight journalism?

JM: Journalism has prompted insights and action for hundreds of years, whether it be social or political change, or taking entertainment, sports and culture to the public. Journalism entertains, as well as informs.

Although many stories have created change - at local, national and international stages - many stories have not been responded to. Or, sometimes, never been heard at all.

Insight Journalism is journalism with a different structure: journalism placed within a different environment. Essentially, Insight Journalism - whether operating in a small community or international corporation is supported by a structure and individuals who can listen, understand and react.

But the crucial and exciting element, and an element that is at the core of the concept, is that those with the power to create change and react, will be held to account by the journalists or storytellers who work in an open, transparent and journalistic fashion.

THOSE WITH THE POWER TO CREATE CHANGE AND REACT, WILL BE HELD TO ACCOUNT BY THE JOURNALISTS OR STORYTELLERS WHO WORK IN AN OPEN, TRANSPARENT AND JOURNALISTIC FASHION

FG: Why do you think it is interesting?

JM: Insight Journalism offers a radical and ranging opportunity for groups, organisations, communities and commercial operations to uncover 'insights' and act upon them.

Through journalistic questioning and storytelling from professional, citizen or non-journalists, revelations can be uncovered.

The key thing about this process, and what makes it different from other forms of journalism, is the model that supports this inquiry and (re)action. The actions and responses to these stories, and the holding of these actions and those responsible for them to account makes

FG: Where are the best environments to deploy an insight journalist?

JM: Insight Journalists can be deployed around a wide range of scenarios. They can work with in geographic communities, communities of interest, organisations and commercial entities.

Wherever there are people, there are stories, and scope to reveal insights on which to act.

As long as the journalists are equipped with the skills and equipment to produce reports and carry out journalistic enquiry, and have access to an infrastructure to support them, there seems to be no limit.

CITIZEN

Dhee Burr, a sometime presenter, blogger, social entrepreneur, social media addict and citizen journalist shares his experiences on what it was like to work on BESPOKE as a community journalist.

My experience with BESPOKE initially began in an employed context, as the project partnered with two other organisations dedicated to bring community journalism to two areas of Preston. Yet that project was short-lived by design and I found myself enamoured with the ethos behind the entire project, so I continued to volunteer.

The thinking was simple; utilising community journalists to uncover the challenges that local residents felt were the most important, and then presenting these challenges to the designers along with a variety of contributions from residents, local service providers and those directly involved with any potential solutions such as the local councillor.

Fulfilment was found in seeing the faces of people when they could see that their concerns had been taken into account. This was the first step in ensuring that all those interviewed knew their contribution counted, and yet still, more was wanted.

It was funny; I was not without strong opinions of my own, yet I found that the views that were presented to me became my own personal focus. Feelings and perceptions that could be echoed across the country had been spelt out in some detail and I found that many people's frustrations echoed my own.

The Viewpoint device for example had arisen out of members of the community feeling isolated from the decision making process. The local reaction as measured by the participation in the survey questions demonstrated just how thirsty people are to be involved, given half a chance.

Both service providers and residents benefited by opening questions to the community, giving results that can be acted upon, and more importantly, letting people know that their views have been heard via more than just an infrequent visit to the ballot box.

FULFILMENT WAS FOUND IN SEEING THE FACES OF PEOPLE WHEN THEY COULD SEE THAT THEIR CONCERNS HAD BEEN TAKEN INTO ACCOUNT

GONZO

"What kind of Story is this?"

"The Mint 400", I said. "It's the richest off-the-road race for motorcycles and dune buggies in the history of organized sport – a fantastic spectacle in honour of some fatback grossero named Del Webb, who owns the luxurious Mint Hotel in the heart of downtown Las Vegas… at least that's what the press release says; my man in New York just read it to me"

"Well," he said, "as you attorney I advise you to buy a motorcycle. How else can you cover a ting like this righteously?"

An extract from Fear And Loathing in Las Vegas.

Hunter S Thompson's blurring between fiction and journalism in order to tell the right story – to get into the places where 'trench coats and fedoras' can't reach provides a fascinating backdrop to traditional academic scholarly activity. Where fiction meets lies in a haze of alcohol and drugs in order to find the truth. Is it not truth that we are in pursuit of rather than professional practice?

But can going Gonzo be any more than a generation-X excuse for aparty? Could it really be used as a serious method for uncovering the unknown?

The idea for Gonzo design came from Fieldguide's good friend and mentor, Rory Hamilton, who first wrote of going gonzo as a design research process in 2005.

"What I mean by Gonzo design is design where the research entails getting involved with your users much more that you normally would. So we are not just studying or documenting the lifestyle or working practices of the user group but becoming part of the group you are researching."

Rory Hamilton,
www.everythingiknow.co.uk. 2005.

In September 2011, the brief to study the impact of digital R&D in the cultural arts sector came by the studio. Following a call from Nesta, we won a pitch led by Dan Dixon to study the processes and experiences of an MIT project with the immersive theatre company Punchdrunk.

And my part of it, having just wrapped up the BESPOKE project, we were going to New York to study a show called Sleep No More. It seemed a natural fit to try a Gonzo approach to Insight Journalism. Could Gonzo Insight Journalism go where ethnography and social sciences could not reach?

The original plan for New York was to have a team of Insight Journalists drawn from both the show community and also from student/professional journalists, but we couldn't make this happen. Which meant that Paul and I, rather than acting as editors of stories, became the writers of stories and as a result were thrown into the journalistic process more than perhaps we wanted to be. Then again, maybe this is how it should be? Dan has these thoughts on it

"What happens when you don't have a community? You don't have anyone to take up the pen or step into the uncomfortable journalistic shoes? Then the designers and researchers are shoved into the front line. They have to take this role of being the journalists, being the content creators, the roving reporters. They go gonzo, the story now about them, no pretend objectivity, no layer of interpretation, no community to take the responsibility for whatever insights come out. It's an ugly business, but someone has to do it."

And that's exactly what we did. While Paul was grabbing interviews with performers, I was trying to get under-the-skin of the design process the MIT students followed, while Dan was taking pictures of the set.

While our original intention was to draw insights about the interactions with experimental technology by commissioning our own Insight Journalists, by becoming the journalists we discovered that Insight Journalism was better suited in this situation to finding the story behind the processes rather than observing interactions.

This provided an unexpected use of Insight Journalism as a tool within organisations. Dan goes further to say that there is something about the authenticity of being not just on the ground, but in the ground of an event or an environment.

"Insights need to come from the ground. There is no truth and there is no right answer, these are concepts for philosophers and politicians. However there is some kind of authenticity and attention that comes from a real, insider's account that no part time reporter can quite get at. Without the insider, authenticity and attention get lost."

WITHOUT THE INSIDER, AUTHENTICITY AND ATTENTION GET LOST

Ultimately, Gonzo Insight Journalism is a way to go beyond the brief of the card-carrying journalist and go off the tracks and uncover new territories. We think there could be something in this for uncovering maybe more societal based issues where people need inspiration from being within – rather than looking in from the outside.

Whether you work in healthcare, education or events, there could be a time when the person sitting next to you scribbling furiously into their notebook might just be an Insight Journalist finding out what you do. Although as Dan sums up the implications for designers can often be uncomfortable.

"My doctor has seriously advised against these practices as they are a threat to both my health and my sanity. In the future I think I'll leave the community journalism to that happily indefinable thing that is the community"

CRITICS

On both the BESPOKE project and when we went Gonzo in NYC, we worked with professional academics to study how we worked.

We wanted to get them to tell you what they thought of the processes and in a way benchmark them to the more established practice of Design Ethnography. Here are their accounts of what they observed…

The Anthropologist
Alicia Blum-Ross

As an anthropologist, I have long been interested in the ways in which different forms of media contribute to creating ethnographic insight. To me, ethnography is a reflexive, emotive process which lends itself to design because of, rather than despite, its inherent subjectivity. At its best, ethnography can not only communicate concrete information, but it can also inspire, create empathy and provoke.

What I began to take note of while observing the designers grapple with making sense of the Insight Journalism was that different media genres produced different kinds of understandings. The articles in the printed newspaper, for instance, were key for the designers as a form of context-setting and information transmission and provided a powerful means of building connections with local groups. However the texts were seen as less evocative and emotive than the journalism that relied more heavily on visuals. Photo-essays were valuable in capturing and exploring a 'moment in time' but overall the team most often cited the video stories as profoundly influencing their design process.

The video stories created by the Insight Journalists were described as constructive because they most closely gave the designers a 'sense of place'. Both in terms of the physical locality as well as the personalities and relationships of those both filming and interviewed.

Moving images allowed designers to understand not just the 'foreground' content in its most edited version, as in the written stories, but also communicated unintentional insights about the area. At one point, a single shot of a signpost in the local park sparked a longer discussion about signage and communication which, cross-referenced with other stories, led to the design of the Wayfinder.

On reflection, I felt that Insight Journalism was an effective tool for doing design ethnography in myriad ways. It enabled the design team to access multiple perspectives and voices in a condensed yet highly evocative summary. Insight Journalism is includes both the process of brokering relationships – requiring skills anthropologists and journalists share – as well as the distillation of journalism into insights within the design process.

As an ethnographer, I would consider Insight Journalism a powerful mechanism, but one that does not eclipse the need for a design anthropologist. The ethnographer's role is still vital in guiding the facilitation, analysis and indeed translation of the Insight Journalism with the design team.

Alicia Blum-Ross is an LSE Fellow in Media and Communications. As a researcher on the BESPOKE project she tool on the dual roles of overall ethnography in addition to working closely with user groups and Insight Journalists in Preston to facilitate feedback on the design responses.

MOVING IMAGES ALLOWED DESIGNERS TO UNDERSTAND NOT JUST THE 'FOREGROUND' CONTENT, BUT ALSO COMMUNICATED UNINTENTIONAL INSIGHTS

The Design Ethnographer
Dan Dixon

For me Insight Journalism is a complement to more traditional design ethnography, if in fact it isn't really another complicated addition to the already action packed repertoire of tools that an ethnographer has at their disposal.

Insight Journalism in one sense is very similar to ethnography in that both are about writing accounts of the world and uncovering the unexpected. They are both deeply concerned with writing about people. However the difference between ethnography and regular journalism is really in that ethnography is, by definition, the writing of cultures, while journalism is the writing of events.

In a research and design sense it is uncovering the banal and the everyday in revealing detail, because these overlooked details often make the difference between success and failure in projects, products and experiences. Journalism on the other hand tends towards big events, the out of the ordinary, the abnormal.

But Insight Journalism, with it's roots strongly in citizen journalism steers away from the big events to the little things that concern people in their everyday lives. And it steers away from pretending to professionalism towards empowering local individuals. It is, ideally, everyday writing by everyday people.

Within social and cultural research there is a strong tradition of what is called autoethnography, a form of writing that explores the researchers own personal experience, ranging from insider accounts to personal narratives of more universal experiences. One thing they all do is to challenge the concept of there being a single objective truth, and the value of these accounts comes out in how useful they are, not how "right" they might be.

From an ethnographers point of view Insight Journalism creates more data to play with, more data to read, more points of view. It helps to extend the capability of the few researchers, designers or observers to be everywhere at once. So in another way it is like outsourced observation, or crowd based ethnographic data collection. Which then makes Insight Journalism somewhat like a scaled up version of autoethnography, not just one account, but many, personal, subjective accounts. A crowdsourced autoethnography.

Dan Dixon is a senior lecturer in creative industries at the University of Western England. researching pervasive, urban, street and mixed-reality gaming.

INSIGHT JOURNALISM CREATES MORE DATA TO PLAY WITH, MORE POINTS OF VIEW

FIELDNOTES

Autoethnography
Is a form of research that uses the writer's subjective, autobiographical experience to reflexively interpret wider cultural situations. It doesn't necessarily engage with other people's practices.

BESPOKE
Is a research project and methodology that puts community citizens at the heart of the engagement process to achieve tailor-made responses to community generated content.

Design Ethnography
Ethnography is the study of culture and more importantly everyday culture. Design ethnography uses the methods of ethnography to describe the everyday world we live in in such a way that insights can be drawn that will help the design of products and services.

Discourse Analysis
Is to describe a set of cognitive psychology tools that have been adapted for further understanding or gaining insights into written, vocal or sign language. And like Semiotic Tools it is commonly used as a critical tool for understanding what a journalist is really saying.

Gamification
Is the use of game design elements in non-game contexts

Gonzo
According to my copy of Harper Perienial Classics additional notes Gonzo was "about getting at the truth, even if it mean, technically, lying" and as Thompson himself said "The best fiction is far more true than any kind of journalism – and the best journalists know that".

Wayfinder
The Wayfinder is a design response that came out of Insight Journalism during the BESPOKE project. It displays and physically points to community event information on the Callon and Fishwick Estate in Preston.

Semiotic Tools
A set of research tools to uncover underlying meaning behind text and media content.

GUIDE

Here Paul explains more about the process of Insight Journalism, breaking it down into the tasks that a journalist would perform and the way in which insights are gathered and reported.

The three stage process, enables you to: Plan how the client wants to frame the scope of work through protoyping and priming of expected outcomes; in the Publish stage we play the game of being journalists and tell our stories back to the client; and Present the processed insights to provide an evidence framework that could enable [re]action by the client.

Plan
During the planning stage Insight Journalism editors confer with the 'client' organisation/stakeholders to agree the scope of the Insight Journalism exercise. Here all parties agree the style and tone of the editorial approach and address issues of confidentiality or any commercial sensitivities.

The choice of publishing platform - online or print (or both) is agreed along with the frequency of publication and the timescales for the overall project.

At this stage the entire process is usually communicated to everyone involved in the project. Stakeholders are primed to participate, encouraged to submit thoughts, ideas and observations. They are offered training in story telling if this is appropriate.

A 'first edition' of the publication is delivered offering a range of styles within it. The stories in the prototype are largely descriptive and are intended as a benchmark to ensure the Insight team understand the core values and key functions of the client organisation and its relationship with all its stakeholders.

Publish
A 'gamification' of the act of journalism occurs during the publishing stage of the process. Insight Journalists treat the project as their 'beat' patch much as a local journalist would a community.

They are proactively looking for stories with some news value within the framework of the project so their reporting is not passive. They develop professional relationships with all parties conducting a series of interviews with a range of participants recording them using mobile phones, lightweight video cameras or audio recorders. They take photographs. They write up their interviews – framing them as stories with story 'headlines' - much as reporters in a news operation would. They encourage stakeholders to produce their own stories (anonymously if they wish) and to submit user-generated content supplying them with the appropriate technology to enable them to do this.

The stories they produce are then published in print and/or as media rich websites and delivered back to the 'client' organisation within the agreed timescale.

Present
The presentation of Insights gathered during the publishing phase occurs after the text, video and audio stories have been assessed and analysed. Standard discourse analysis and linguistic or semiotic tools are applied during the analysis of the content within each story.

Stories are then graded simply for the level of insight they produce. After this process, the Insight Journalism method is applied once more to produce a final series of stories to summarise the insights gathered during the course of the project. The aim of this process is to create a robust evidence route to activity.

Insights
Paul now takes a look at the meaning and classification of insights gathered. This is important as it makes open the process of how insights are gathered and what use they might be.

Four star Insights will draw out underlying ('real') issues and motivations but may also include elements of other categories of 'Insights'.

Real issue insights examine the cause and effect of the issue. They reveal the tensions and conflicts between stakeholders responsible for/or tackling an issue, delivering a product or managing a process. They examine the impact the issue is having on those affected by it. They raise questions related to the above.

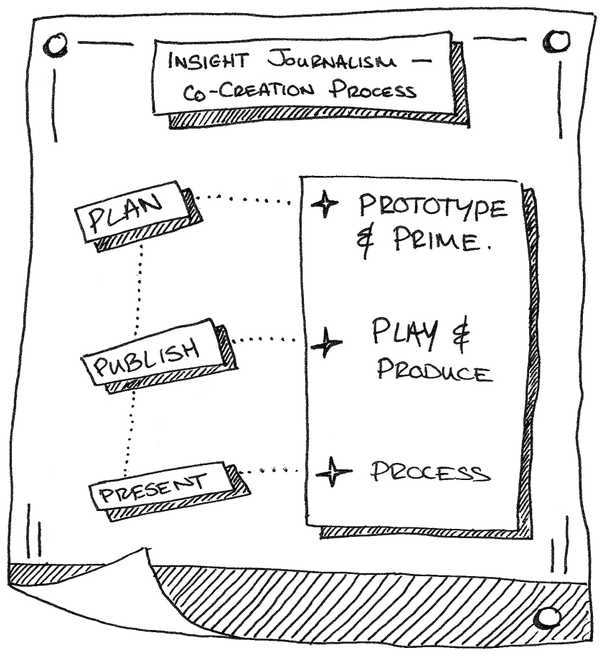
Three star Insights are likely to be contextual dealing with the history of an issue or problem. They may include elements of insight categories one and two.

Local stories, semi structured interviews, research into previous media coverage (where appropriate) Here we need to bring in data – particularly live data, scrapers and processing of data. What are the inherent biases?

Two star Insights are largely descriptive. They will contain useful information about the topic but are more likely to be presented as reporting.

Descriptive insights are detailed descriptions of an issue, place or policy/rule. Descriptive insights offer detail about who the main stakeholders are, where the issue occurs. Descriptive Insights are factual, unbiased and representative - are these quality thresholds?. They will include unmediated user generated content within the packaged item/piece.

One star Insights are likely to be entirely superficial. They will comprise the oversimplified presentation of an issue or problem perhaps based on largely anecdotal evidence from 3rd party sources. Such insights may become the first stage of a series of insights and the catalyst for commissioned pieces on a particular issue.



NEXT

Our next issue is The London Design Festival Issue which celebrates our first exhibition.

We've been invited by Brompton Design District to be part of their contribution to London Design Festival at 4 Cromwell Place. The BDD exhibition brings together projects by designers from the UK, Europe and Africa whose focus is people and how we live our everyday lives in changing times; hallmarking curiosity, openness and inventiveness.

For our bit we've curated a mini exhibition bringing together a mix of Fieldguide friends: designers, technologists; artists; musicians and journalists to show some of their most exciting work from the last year. These projects, prototypes and products will demonstrate how insight journalism can be used as a tool for design research, how paper can connect to the internet, how ink can turn an object on and off and how interactive storytelling can challenge our perceptions of memory. Wow! Here's who's taking part...

Brendan Dawes & Bare Conductive
Digital Cultures Research Centre
FOUND & Aidan Moffat
Insight Journalism Live
Interactive Newsprint & Garry Cook
Patrick Stevenson-Keating
Product Research Studio
UK Journalism
Uniform

www.findplaymake.com

THANKS

Where to start! Fieldguide has been a massive team effort - it wouldn't have happened without Jon, Pete, Mike and Tom who thought up the caper. Toby who prompted us to move just that little bit faster. Paul, John, Dan, Alicia and Dhee for providing the clever bits. And big thanks to Michelle Ford for sorting all the print out!

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Nesta

Research Councils UK Digital Economy – Transforming Business and Society

Uniform

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Printed on Oikos 80gsm
Paper supplied by Fedrigoni Paper UK


JOURNALİSM